The tip-off sparked the #FreeBritney movement by her obsessive fanbase. What was once thought to be another internet conspiracy theory turned out to be true. An online and physical protest movement sprang up and brought her plight to public attention, which led to hundreds gathering outside the Los Angeles courthouse on the day a judge ended the legal conservatorship of Britney's father.

What is clear from this case study is the role of empathy and connection in PSRs. Many of Spears' fans had two decades to build their own one-sided connections with Spears. And, yet, it was social media and new media technologies that led to global concern for her welfare and a huge movement to eventually free her from her father's legal control.

Analysis

1. Explore the popularity of the #FreeBritney hashtag. How many times has it been used across a range of social media platforms?
2. What role do you believe PSRs played in the growth of the #FreeBritney campaign?
3. Similar global campaigns to free political prisoners like Nelson Mandela and Aung San Suu Kyi have used the media and grassroots activism to bring attention to their cause. Explore the history of these campaigns. How is the #FreeBritney event different?
4. Explore the story of the #FreeBritney campaign. How did PSR play a role in inspiring the movement?

New media audiences: Citizen journalism

Citizen journalism is the practice of ordinary citizens, or groups of citizens, playing an active role in the process of collecting, reporting, analysing and disseminating news and information.[7] In short, these are ordinary people without journalism training or being employed by a media company, who are collecting and publishing news. The development of digital media technologies in the past decade has made this a growing trend. Considering the global pandemic of 2020–22, audiences have sought to publish their voices more frequently and the audience for alternative media sources has been growing steadily for a decade.

A 2021 University of Canberra study on the state of Australian news media found the following:

AUSTRALIAN NEWS MEDIA CONSUMERS

- Only 13% of Australians paid for online news, and most (83%) said it was unlikely they would pay in the future.
- 23% of news consumers primarily used social media for news, which had risen 5% in two years.
- Most Australians (80%) said they had not read a newspaper or magazine in the past week.

FIGURE 6.34 University of Canberra study on the state of Australian news media

What was obvious from the study is that Australian audiences (and many around the world) are turning to social media for news, as trust in broadcast-era news sources has slowly been eroded by the deluge of information online. One of the fastest-growing areas has been on Twitter, where political commentary from both sides of the spectrum has risen to amass large audiences. Enter the citizen journalist. Several individuals have taken it upon themselves to step into the space of political commentary online, such as FriendlyJordies in New South Wales and the mysterious 'PR Guy' in Victoria.

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One of the more remarkable citizen journalists to arrive in the last decade has been teenage self-publishing journalist Leo Puglisi. Head of his own 'Channel 6 news', Puglisi focuses on Australian politics through his homemade news broadcasts (his parents help out between his homework schedule) and high-profile Twitter presence. During the 2022 federal election, his running joke of 'I wouldn't vote for them' (he couldn't, he was 14 at the time) drew the ire of politicians, trolls and political hardliners from the left and right. Nevertheless, his 34 000+ followers watched on as his rising profile gathered him interviews with former Prime Minister Kevin Rudd and then-current PM Scott Morrison, and checked in with his daily news coverage. Puglisi does not have an axe to grind like other citizen journalists, and his audience are attracted to the somewhat naive, yet refreshingly unbiased views of a teenager engaged with Australian politics.

ACTIVITY 6.14

Research task

Watch examples of Puglisi's 'Channel 6 news' online.

1. Explain how you would be able to launch your own news broadcast. List the technologies and process required to get your news broadcast online.
2. What does the popularity of 'Channel 6 news' and other citizen journalist sites tell you about the capacity for the audience to challenge traditional news media?

6.4 How audiences interact and engage with new media forms

LEARNING INTENTIONS

By the end of this chapter section, you will have learnt about:

- the ways audiences interact and engage with the media as a result of the growth of technologies across media forms.

The sheer volume of internet users, available content and services, and the data they collect can seem more complex to comprehend than the worlds beyond our own planet. Media use has not only increased, but diversified in ways that the broadcast era could never have imagined.

Atomisation of audiences

As you have already learnt in this chapter, new media technologies have allowed audiences a means to interact and engage with the media in a range of ways. In perhaps the biggest blow to the model of the broadcast era, audiences have become '**atomised**'. In short, audiences have been broken up into millions of small, dedicated audiences that consume very specific content. A broad look at the streaming service Netflix will reveal an extremely broad range of sub-topics, genres and interests, as there is a devoted audience for almost any kind of content. YouTube has an untold number of devoted fan bases for specific ideas and interests.

atomised the process of media audiences breaking into more and more specific categories of interest

Across the web, there are forums, sites, YouTube and social media groups and channels dedicated to every passing interest you have ever had, or don't know that you have yet.

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